

Recovery Made SMARTer— Together.

SMART Recovery Australia and Aotearoa NZ
2025-2028 Strategic Plan
DRAFT Sept. 2025



Acknowledgment of Country

We acknowledge the unceded and continuous connection to Country, water, and community. We pay our respects to Elders past and present and acknowledge community controlled Aboriginal organisations that we work with around the country. We value self-determination, we learn by looking back and as we look to the future we center deep listening and collaboration in our work.



Our 'Why'— and Your Invitation

Together we are creating a
community of peer support
that's **SMART**.



GROWTH

SMART Recovery is a **growing community** — building **hope**, **connection**, and **change**. At our heart, we provide **world-class training** and digital tools, **empowering** our facilitators to run **peer support** meetings.



ACTIVATION

We begin with **changing public perceptions** and making **recovery** feel relatable and **possible for everyone**. Next, we **activate** our **partnerships** with our Member Organisations, peak bodies, digital innovators, and communities to embed SMART into the wider health and justice **ecosystem**. Finally, we grow our **heart**: our facilitators. Their **growth**, **confidence**, and application of SMART tools will fuel our **success**.



RECOGNITION

We **recognise** our **people** are our greatest asset and we acknowledge their **commitment**, **contribution** and **wellbeing** are essential to our success.



COMMITMENT

Wherever people are in the **cycle of change**, our **commitment** is to provide the right **tools** at the right **time** to **support** them on their **journey**.



SUPPORT

We support **communities** to respond to addiction with **compassion** and **evidence**.

Over the next three years, we will expand our **impact**: changing the way addiction is **understood**, showcasing the **power** of peer support, and forging partnerships that make recovery possible for **more people**, in **more places**.



CONNECTION

This is more than a strategy. It's an **invitation** to rethink addiction and peer support, and an **opportunity** to **connect** with **change** in **action**.

SMART RECOVERY AUSTRALIA AND AOTEAROA NZ STRATEGY

2025-28



Transforming the perception of Addiction

We shift how society views addiction and positioning it not as a fixed identity but as a changeable human experience. Through targeted initiatives with GPs, justice institutions, legal professions and AOD services, and by amplifying living expertise, we lead a public conversation that showcases the evidence and power of peer support.



Partnership-Driven Innovation

We co-design bold, innovative solutions with government, community and research partners. By leveraging resources, alliances and insights SMART expands its reach, credibility, and impact. We prioritise youth, underserved and under-supported communities, and where welcomed, we partner with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities, Māori, and Pacifica communities to ensure solutions are culturally-grounded, strengths-based, and community-led.



Empowering Facilitators

Facilitators are the heart of SMART. We are growing a connected network of trained leaders through comprehensive training, communities of practice, marketing and practical resources. Their confidence and capacity will make peer support scalable, effective, and visible across diverse communities.



Our Vision for Recovery

By the year 2028, SMART will be known as the leading peer-led recovery movement in Australia and Aotearoa NZ. The goal is to make peer support not only accessible but also empowering and recognisable across diverse communities, thereby fostering a culture of acceptance and support.

OUR PRINCIPLES OF CHANGE



Peer Power

Recovery is strongest when people support each other and know they are not alone.



The Power of Choice

Everyone deserves recovery options that reflect their unique needs and goals. Peer support can enhance clinical outcomes by providing connection and lived experience alongside treatment. At the same time, it offers a non-clinical pathway for those who prefer alternatives to abstinence-only models. By broadening the recovery landscape, peer support ensures people are not limited to a single definition of success but empowered to choose what works best for them.



Evidence and Innovation

We combine lived experience and living expertise with data, research, and digital innovation to drive change.



Health Equity

Access to peer support is a right, no matter where you live, who you are, or if you are living with a disability.



Self-Determination

Communities are best placed to shape their own solutions; we walk alongside, not ahead. We honour the distinctive knowledges of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander, and Māori ways of being and doing, connection to identity, country, cultural practices, whānau, and community in recovery.



Bold Advocacy

We disrupt outdated practices and influence policy, funding, and the current culture of addiction support so peer support is recognised and resourced.



Collective Responsibility

As a community we need to do more to support people experiencing addiction so they can live their best lives. We act together to build stronger pathways to recovery for everyone.



Collaboration

We work across justice, health, mental health, and community systems to make peer support central to recovery.

Pillar 1: We change the narrative

Making Recovery Accessible, Relatable and
Not Stigmatised



Reframe Addiction as Changeable

We educate the public and professionals that addiction is not a moral failing but a human experience that can change. We all do some things more or less than we want to. Through powerful storytelling, we highlight recovery as possible, relatable, and achievable with SMART peer support. We centre empowerment and agency in our storytelling.



Tailor Messaging by Sector

We engage GPs, legal professionals, AOD services, youth workers, mental health practitioners, and diverse communities with messaging that speaks directly to their context and priorities, building awareness and credibility.



Campaign Across Platforms

We practice collective action and lead national conversations about SMART as a pathway to recovery. We harness social media, podcasts, local radio, and visual storytelling to shift mindsets and expand SMART's reach. We make SMART a visible and accessible pathway to change.



Elevate Lived Experience Voices:

We empower our Facilitators and Participants as storytellers. Their voices build authenticity, shift perceptions, and ensure SMART is recognised across Australia and Aotearoa NZ as a trusted, evidence-based movement.

Pillar 2:

We partner for impact

Co-Designing Growth with our Strategic Partners



Drive Visibility & Evaluation:

Show the impact of SMART peer-led recovery

We partner with leading researchers to demonstrate the effectiveness, reach, and adaptability of peer-led recovery across diverse communities.



Build Sector-Spanning Partnerships:

Embed SMART across recovery ecosystems

We engage and train our Member Organisations, peak bodies, GPs, AOD services, PHN's, legal networks, and mental health organisations to ensure SMART is integrated, recognised, and valued.



Innovate Through Co-Design:

Co-create inclusive, culturally relevant SMART tools

We create the next generation of SMART tools and Partner with digital innovators, AI developers, and cultural leaders to design solutions that are inclusive, culturally relevant, and future-ready. Where our input is welcomed and adds value, we form partnerships with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities, Māori and Pacifica communities sharing ownership of work and peer led solutions.



Lead with Evidence:

Shape policy and practice through proven outcomes

We influence policy and practice at every level. Leverage outcomes data, research partnerships, and innovation pilots to ensure governments and sector partners adopt peer-led recovery as a proven and scalable solution.

Pillar 3:

We grow our community of Facilitators

Strengthening the SMART Community from within



Empower the Facilitator Community

Recognise facilitators as leaders and movement builders. Provide platforms for peer connection, facilitator resources, learning, and celebration.



Innovate for Reach and Relevance

Expand programs and training to support underserved and under supported communities. Harness digital delivery models, ensuring flexibility and accessibility.



Communities of Practice

Deliver and grow communities of practice to increase confidence, meeting commencement and consistency.



Incentivise Longevity & Leadership

Create meaningful recognition and leadership pathways for facilitators, ensuring they feel valued, supported, and motivated to stay engaged for the long term.

Pillar 4:

We attract and engage a high performing team that thrive

Our People Thrive and Our Community
Grows



INVESTING

We ensure organisational excellence and are known as an Employer of Choice by investing in our team through a high quality people and culture development strategy that spans the lifecycle of employment.



UPLIFTING

We support strong, visionary and inspirational leadership.



SUPPORTING

We foster a culture of wellbeing, inclusion and collaboration, where every team member feels valued, supported and empowered to contribute their best and where their efforts are aligned with the purpose and direction of the organisation.



INSPIRING

Our people are energised and inspired by SMART's strategy, seeing clearly how their work contributes to a larger mission of peer-led recovery and social impact.

VISION 2028: WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

SMART as a Relatable, Visible, Peer-Led Movement



**SMART is the #1 Peer Community
in Australia/Aotearoa New Zealand**

Recognised and respected by healthcare, community and justice services for evidence-based, peer-led recovery.



**Narrative
Shifted**

Addiction is viewed as a human experience open to change, not a fixed condition or source of stigma. Peer support is part of the everyday conversation and recovery support is a social expectation.



**Facilitators at the
Forefront**

A confident, diverse facilitator network leading SMART sessions across age groups, cultures, and platforms.



**Scaling Impact through Tools
and Partnerships**

SMART tools are used by our Member organisations and Strategic Partners to support people to live their best lives.

OUR PEOPLE THRIVE AND OUR COMMUNITY GROWS

OUR SHARED VISION:

By 2028, we will be known for leading communities of peer support across Australia and Aotearoa NZ.



Our SMART approach has redefined how diverse communities view and engage with addiction and peer support. Addiction is understood as a human experience and peer support is vital to helping people live their best lives.



SMART Recovery will be embedded across sectors, powered by partnerships, and led by our engaged community of Facilitators.



Our facilitators will be recognised leaders, shaping recovery in diverse communities, schools and digitally.



The narrative around addiction will have fundamentally shifted, opening pathways for more people to seek support and experience change.



This vision is about **transformation**. It's SMART Recovery becoming a household name and creating a community of peer support that is SMART— together.



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THE SMART ALTERNATIVE TO RECOVERY

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NEXT STEPS: A COMMUNITY IN MOTION

Executing SMART's 2025-2028 Strategy requires phased, strategic action.



Laying The Foundations

We begin by reshaping public narratives and forging the partnerships that will power long-term change.



Expanding Reach

Growth accelerates as we scale facilitator networks and formalise strategic alliances to deepen impact.



Embedding & Evaluating

SMART becomes integrated into national systems, with a strong focus on measuring outcomes and learning from our progress.



Leading the Movement

SMART stands recognised and funded as the leading peer recovery community across Australia and Aotearoa NZ with a growing community of facilitators across the Asia Pacific region.

2025

2026

2027

2028